

Hope, expect, and possibility

Teaching guide

Separate what you want from what you think is likely.

Understand the distinction

Hope expresses a desired outcome. Expect expresses a belief about what is likely. May, might, and could express possibility. Will can express a prediction, a decision, or willingness; context matters.

These words are not a fixed percentage scale. I hope it rains does not tell us how likely rain is. I expect a delay can express an unwelcome prediction. Keep facts, wishes, and uncertainty distinct.

Compare the patterns

WISH

I hope the train is on time.

This is the outcome I want.

EXPECTATION

I expect the train to be late.

This is what I think is likely.

POSSIBILITY

The train might be late.

A delay is possible, not certain.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Which expresses a wish: I hope we win / I expect we will win?

2. Rewrite as a possibility: The office will close early.

3. Does I expect a problem mean I want one?

Use it in your own life

Write a hope and a cautious prediction about tomorrow.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. I hope we win.

Hope identifies a desired outcome.

2. The office might close early.

Might reduces the certainty. May or could also works.

3. No. It expresses a belief, not a wish.

An expectation can be unwelcome.

One possible response

I hope the weather is good. It might rain in the afternoon.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-08.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Ask learners to explain the differences between the comparison examples before reading the rules. Use their answers to identify the point that needs attention.

2. Explain and check (4 minutes)

Read the short explanation together. Keep its qualifications: a common pattern is not necessarily a rule for every context. Ask learners to give a counterexample where the lesson mentions an exception.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Write a hope and a cautious prediction about tomorrow.

Have learners work alone, then compare with a partner. Ask the partner to restate the intended meaning before suggesting a correction.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Use the answer explanations to review the three checks. Accept natural alternatives that preserve the intended meaning. Ask each learner to revise one sentence and identify the change.

Extension

Change the person, time, place, or purpose in a comparison example. Ask whether the original pattern still fits and why. Revisit one example in the next lesson.

Feedback criteria

Meaning: the message is understandable. Form: the target pattern fits the context. Transfer: the learner can use it in a fresh example. This short activity is not a proficiency certification.